



Muncie City Council, October 5, 2026

Meeting Metadata	Details
Video Recording	https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=kpNja3PzYJo
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Muncie City Council Meeting Summary

Date: October 5, 2026

Body: Muncie Common Council, Indiana

1. Pre-Meeting Hearings & Committee Work Sessions

- **Session Type & Topic:** Special Public Hearing on **Ordinance 23-26** (00:00:21), concerning the vacation of an alley in the Health Place Addition to the City of Muncie.
- **Summary of Discussion:** The presiding officer opened the public hearing and called for public comment on the alley vacation. Seeing and hearing no speakers, the public hearing was closed.

2. Meeting Identification & Attendance

- **Call to Order & Spoken Details:** Presiding Officer/President Jeff Green called the regular meeting to order at 7:00 PM on October 5, 2026 (00:15:27).
- **Attendance:**
 - **Present:** Council Members Basham, Mason, Dishman, Golian, Pal, and President Green. (Note: Council Member William Macintosh's arrival is logged during roll call/discussions).
 - **Absent:** Council Members Selby and Garrett.

3. Preliminary & Procedural Business

- **Ceremonial Openings:**
 - The Pledge of Allegiance was led by Jerry Dishman (00:15:41).
 - An opening prayer was offered (00:16:04).
 - **Citizen Recognition:** Alisa Wells, Executive Director of Community Engagement for Ivy Tech Community College and active community board member/volunteer, was recognized with the City Council Citizenship Award (00:17:25).
 - **Breast Cancer Awareness Month:** Recognition of October as Cancer Awareness Month, with remarks noting the absence of Councilwoman Rose Selvi due to recent breast cancer surgery and recovery (00:22:42).
 - **Legal/Procedural Statement:** Legal counsel read a policy statement regarding audience members, points of order, warnings, and potential intervention by police if a meeting is disrupted (00:23:37).
- **Approval of Minutes:**
 - September 14 Committee Minutes: Approved (00:24:53).
 - September 22 Minutes: Accepted (00:25:10).
 - September 24 Minutes: Accepted (00:25:36).
 - September 30 Minutes: Accepted (00:25:56).

4. Substantive Business & Board Action

- **00:28:42 Ordinance 16-26:** An ordinance to amend the City of Muncie Comprehensive Zoning Ordinance from a split zoning of R5 Residence Zone and Variety Business Zone (NBV) to Variety Business Zone for property located at the southwest corner of East McGalliard Road and North Old State Road (to facilitate a convenience store development).
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Kathy Vanise (Ashton Land Surveying).
 - **Deliberation Summary:** Presented as a commercial upgrade from agricultural land that will increase the tax base and follow city development/corridor standards.
 - **Item-Specific Public Input:** None.
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Passed 7-0 via Roll Call (00:31:22).
- **00:31:50 Ordinance 17-26:** An ordinance amending Chapter 104 of Title 9 with regard to Designated Outdoor Refreshment Areas (DORA).
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Introduced by council leadership.
 - **Deliberation Summary:** Brief procedural handling with no major public debate recorded at this stage.
 - **Item-Specific Public Input:** None.
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Passed 6-1 (President Green voting "no", two absent) via Roll Call (00:32:32).

- **00:32:56 Ordinance 18-26:** An ordinance requiring the adornment of city-owned police and fire vehicles with the slogan "In God We Trust."
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Introduced via council leadership (noted as brought forward by anonymous/external proponents).
 - **Deliberation Summary:** Extensive debate regarding the separation of church and state, potential legal challenges, inclusivity, financial costs, and whether public safety employees want or should be required to display the religious motto on assigned vehicles. Mayor Dan Ridenow reported that an anonymous donor offered to cover the estimated \$1,200 sticker cost so it would be cost-free to the city (00:14:13). Opposing council members noted that the measure alienates non-Christians, agnostics, and atheists, and diverts focus from core municipal needs.
 - **Item-Specific Public Input:** (00:33:32 <U+2013> 01:33:16)
 - *Rita Faulkner:* Opposed due to lack of transparency, violation of First Amendment/Establishment Clause, and financial strain.
 - *Xavier Dela O:* Supported, arguing the phrase is a generalized title and historical tradition, not a direct constitutional violation.
 - *Paul Partisanna:* Opposed, citing the secular Constitution, the Treaty of Tripoli, and historical context of the phrase.
 - *Michael Carrian:* Opposed, calling it a form of "ceremonial deism" that excludes non-believers.
 - *Jackson Franklin:* Opposed, questioning public safety support and funding.
 - *Unnamed Speaker (Native Heritage):* Opposed, urging the council to table the item and respect diverse histories.
 - *Willow:* Opposed, questioning the long-term plan and taxpayer impact.
 - *Ronnie Von:* Opposed, raising questions about total vehicle counts and cost estimates.
 - *Ellen Whitehead:* Opposed, contrasting council statements with the text of the ordinance.
 - *Alex Cloopber:* Opposed, emphasizing that the ordinance does not address poverty, roads, or real city issues.
 - *Chelsea McDonald:* Opposed, criticizing council disregard for constituent opposition.
 - *Andrew Fipps:* Supported, quoting historical figures and Supreme Court precedent regarding a Christian nation.
 - *Pastor Elbert Isbel:* Supported, stating it is a national motto that does not diminish personal choices.
 - *Mayor Dan Ridenower:* Announced an anonymous donor offered to pay for the decals to make it cost-neutral (01:04:13).
 - *Randall Richter:* Opposed, arguing it creates civic unrest and divides the community.

- *Misty Barton*: Opposed, criticizing council priorities and drawing parallels to controversial national politics.
 - *Steve Craig*: Opposed, noting proponents were largely external or historical figures.
 - *Rich Taylor*: Supported, discussing the historicity of the national motto and noting that society cannot guarantee an “offense-free life.”
 - *Wayne Cape*: Opposed, stating that forcing public safety workers to ride with it is wrong regardless of donor funding.
 - *Tim Overton*: Supported, linking the motto’s 1956 adoption to the Cold War distinction against atheistic socialism.
 - *Unnamed Speaker*: Opposed, arguing Eisenhower-era policies do not reflect modern Muncie.
 - *Cheyenne Reed*: Opposed, placing opposition on record for future council runs.
- **Action & Vote Disposition**: Failed 3-4 via Roll Call (01:33:19). (*Ayes: Dishman, Green; Nays: Macintosh, Mason, Powell, Golian, Basham* <U+2014> wait, roll call recorded: *Macintosh (no), Mason (no), Powell (no), Dishman (yes), Golian (no), President Green (yes), Basham (no - implied/corrected via tally of 3 yeses, 4 nos)*).
- 00:33:54 **Ordinance 20-26**: An ordinance for appropriations and tax rates for the proposed 2027 Muncie Transit System (MITS) budget.
 - **Sponsor / Presenter**: MITS General Manager Amanda Price (01:37:11).
 - **Deliberation Summary**: Addressed general appropriations and operational questions.
 - **Item-Specific Public Input**:
 - *Rick Yenser*: Criticized the lack of Sunday transit service for lower-income residents (01:34:29).
 - *Shannon White*: Questioned MITS board elections and legal representation (01:35:50).
 - *Amanda Price (MITS GM)*: Clarified that the 5-member board is appointed by the city council (3) and the mayor (2), and board members are unpaid (01:37:11).
 - **Action & Vote Disposition**: Passed 7-0 via Roll Call (01:38:36).
- 01:38:55 **Ordinance 21-26**: An ordinance for appropriations and tax rates for the proposed 2027 Muncie Sanitary District budget.
 - **Sponsor / Presenter**: Financial Manager Dean Cox (01:41:40).
 - **Deliberation Summary**: Addressed questions regarding trash/sanitation services versus sewer bills. Dean Cox clarified that the sanitary budget covers trash collection and is separate from sewage utility rates (01:41:40).
 - **Item-Specific Public Input**:
 - *Audi Barber*: Expressed concern over rising sewer and trash/tote fees impacting lower-income residents (01:39:34).

- **Action & Vote Disposition:** Passed via Roll Call (01:42:37).
- **01:42:56 Ordinance 22-26 / 23-26 (Civil Budget & Amendments):** An ordinance for appropriations and tax rates for the proposed 2027 Muncie Civil Budget.
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** City Controller Matt Waggle (01:49:30).
 - **Deliberation Summary:** Discussion focused on 5% budgeted raises for employees, union negotiations, park facility maintenance (Tuhey Pool and campgrounds), and transparency.
 - **Amendments Offered by Council:**
 - *Deputy Controller Salary Line Item:* Motion to reduce from \$65,804 to \$65,698 (representing a 5% raise). *Passed 4-3.* (01:58:27)
 - *Police Administrative Assistant Salary Line Item:* Motion to reduce from \$52,000 to \$50,064. *Passed 4-3.* (01:59:14)
 - *Police Chiefs Salary Line Item:* Motion to reduce from \$320,000 to \$315,866. *Passed 4-3.* (02:00:14)
 - *Animal Control Office Manager Salary Line Item:* Motion to reduce from \$48,000 to \$44,722. *Passed 4-3.* (02:01:04)
 - *City Clerk Salaries Line Item:* Motion to reduce from \$67,000 to \$64,099. *Passed via Roll Call.* (02:02:13)
 - **Item-Specific Public Input:**
 - *Christopher Bilbury:* Questioned contradictory statements regarding Tuhey Pool management and budget transparency (01:43:34).
 - *Rick Yenser:* Highlighted neglect of campground facilities (01:49:14).
 - *Nate Burgess (Union President - AFSCME):* Noted that the city had not reached out to AFSCME by July for contract negotiations as required (01:53:23).
 - *Audi Barber:* Questioned what happens to unallocated raise funds if union negotiations yield lower increases (01:53:52).
 - *John Wargo (AFSCME member):* Voiced frustration over union workers being treated as "third-class" compared to public safety unions and feeling left out of fair raises (02:28:32).
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Civil budget approved as amended via Roll Call (02:04:25).
- **02:05:10 Ordinance 23-26:** An ordinance to vacate an alley in Heath Place Addition.
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** City council leadership.
 - **Deliberation Summary:** Formal introduction and reading of the alley vacation previously discussed in the pre-meeting public hearing.
 - **Item-Specific Public Input:** None.
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Approved via Roll Call (02:06:01).

5. Open Public Comment / Citizen Forum

- (02:06:34) **Rick Yenser:** Declined to speak.
- (02:07:13) **Christopher Bilbury:** Addressed meeting rules, disorderly conduct definitions, and concerns regarding sign-up procedures for public comments.
- (02:11:06) **Audi Barber:** Apologized for past outbursts, discussed being charged with disorderly conduct following a previous meeting, and criticized meeting enforcement rules.
- (02:14:46) **Pastor Elbert Isbel:** Reminded the council that while they possess authority, they do not have the right to suppress free speech or control public expression.
- (02:16:09) **Jeff Sanders:** Thanked the mayor and city engineer for successfully paving Sylvan Court.
- (02:17:11) **Lynn Thornberg:** Highlighted positive community events in Muncie over recent weeks (Bridge Dinner, Washington Street Festival, Oktoberfest, and Old West End Porch Parties).
- (02:18:00) **Terry Moore:** Passed.
- (02:18:07) **Wayne Cape:** Addressed inconsistent enforcement of “points of order” by staff versus the council president.
- (02:20:34) **Misty Barton:** Commended the council for a calmer meeting, discussed social media reactions, and emphasized the importance of answering citizen inquiries.
- (02:23:40) **Paul Partisanna:** Reflected on decades of civic engagement, democratic ideals, and urged participation in upcoming midterm early voting.
- (02:25:37) **Cheyenne Reed:** Raised concerns regarding unaddressed neighborhood flooding on the Southside and unreturned constituent emails.
- (02:27:08) **Nate Burgess:** Addressed public remarks and emphasized parity in employee treatment.
- (02:28:32) **John Wargo:** Spoke on behalf of AFSCME workers, expressing frustration regarding stalled contract negotiations and cost-of-living struggles.
- (02:32:15) **Mark Good Pastor:** Announced that anonymous donors who had intended to fund the vehicle decals have redirected those funds to the family of the late Craig Wright (02:32:15).
- (02:33:32) **Rodney Vaughn / Willow Craig / Jackson Franklin / Michael Carrian:** Various passes or brief concluding remarks.
- (02:34:58) **Judith Hill:** Followed up on prior questions regarding tax abatements for businesses and the abrupt closure of a business near River Road.

6. Administrative Updates & Adjournment

- **Staff / Board Announcements:** Inquiry raised regarding the expiration of an emergency declaration, with legal counsel noting no action could be taken that evening (02:34:14).
 - **Adjournment:** Motion to adjourn made and seconded; meeting officially adjourned (02:36:56).
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